and the methods being used. According to our leaked report, ‘approximately 150 air strikes destroyed 75 buildings, including two mosques’, and the operation ‘stirred up a hornets’ nest across the Al Anbar Province’. As part of the ceasefire agreement, the US insisted that the Al Jazeera journalists be removed from the city. As our leaked document put it, ‘Al Jazeera was claiming that up to 600 Iraqi civilians had been killed by the US offensive. Images of dead children were being displayed repeatedly on televisions around the world.’ The report-writers lamented the fact that there were no embedded Western reporters in the area to present the views of ‘military authorities’.

In November the US attacked Fallujah again. It was later to become famous as the bloodiest battle of the war. The Americans had used white phosphorous as part of their campaign, and while this was perhaps not illegal it was deemed highly controversial at the very least. Indeed, Saddam Hussein’s deployment of white phosphorous against his own people in 1991 was counted a war crime and used as part of the justification for the Allied invasion of 2003. In between the original attack on Fallujah and this second one, the scandal of Abu Ghraib broke in the world’s press – or, as the writer of the report preferred to see it, ignoring American responsibility for this scandal, ‘the insurgents got lucky’.

The work never stopped. I sent the leaked Fallujah document to 3,000 people and waited for the levees to break. Nothing. That was one of the most baffling of all the situations we’ve got into. Just no response. People had been writing about Fallujah for the previous three years; they never had a document from inside the mind of the US military like this one, and yet they didn’t jump on it. I must say, I wasn’t just baffled at my journalistic colleagues at that point, I was ashamed of them. The shallowness exhibited by those correspondents is actually mindblowing, if you think about it, and you are left, or I was left at the time, wondering if the mainstream of Western journalism wasn’t just made up of – there’s no other word – wankers.

But, for the long term, there was a lesson. It would become part of my thinking when it came to the Afghan War Logs. What were the unfakeable metrics in modern journalism? They were sales, hits, take-up and exclusivity. And I had to learn how to use these metrics to get the stories out.